

467*, 607, 720*, 876*, 945, 999*, 1067, 1127, 1175, 1241, 1243, 1270, 1297, 1501*, 1595*, 1598, 1678, 1729*, 1735, 1739, 1751, 1765*, 1827*, 1832*, 1848*, 1874*, 1893*, 2180*, 2298, 2344, 2492, 2494*, 2523, 2541, 2674*, 2774*, 2818*. Twenty-one of them, or virtually half, are classed as Byzantine, but since they only appear once, they are evidently independent of the Byzantine bulk. (Actually, all of the MSS that appear here are independent of the Byzantine bulk, except 607.) So we have 43 independent witnesses to **f**³⁵ readings that **are certainly not part of that family**.

Twelve MSS appear only twice, but there is no pattern, no overlap, except for three with the same distribution; so we have ten more independent witnesses. Those that appear more than twice generally reflect some dependency, but even so, they add another ten independent witnesses. When I say ‘independent’, I mean in their generation. There will presumably be grouping as we move back through the centuries. Still, would the 63 independent witnesses in their generation reduce by more than half by the time we got back to the fifth century? I very much doubt it; I would expect at least 30 lines¹ still in the fifth century. Would they reduce by more than half in two centuries? If not, we would still have 15 lines in the third century; which would mean that **f**³⁵ is very early.

Going back to the chart, I note that *ιθυνοντος* and *νομου* share only one MS out of 23; but *ιθυνοντος* and *ημων* share none at all out of 26! *ιθυνοντος* and *επειτα* share only one out of 26; *ιθυνοντος* and *δυναμενος* share none at all out of 31! *νομου* and *ημων* share three out of 31; *νομου* and *επειτα* share two out of 35; *νομου* and *δυναμενος* share only two out of 37. *ου* is the champion, having 18 MSS by itself. So what does this evidence tell us? Does it not indicate that **f**³⁵ is the core from which a great many tangents departed? There is very little pattern, which indicates that **f**³⁵ must be both ancient and independent. The MSS that agree with **f**³⁵ six times out of the eight may prove to be on the fringe of the family; those that agree five times would be farther away, and so on.

Now let us look at 1 John. Whereas in James they included 77 Byzantine MSS (including **f**³⁵), for 1 John they included only 48, so the bias is stronger. Again they included seven to represent the excluded MSS, GA

¹ I understand that someone may well say: “Wait just a minute; on what basis do you say that all those independent MSS represent lines of transmission?” Well, the readings that they attest are not the sort that a copyist would invent on his own initiative. If the copyist did not invent it, then the reading was in his exemplar. If the reading was in his exemplar, then you have a line of transmission. To attempt to gage the length of the ‘lines’, and any relationship between lines, we need complete collations of a great many more MSS.